enhancements. Riots then occurred in Amritsar, Lahore and Rawalpindi. Ajit Singh was accused of trying to spread disaffection amongst the troops and students.

The scene is once again portrayed well in one of the early Bollywood films on Bhagat Singh in 1965. A further comment on this is due. The grainy crackling black-and-white film shows how early on Ajit Singh comes to the aid of a peasant farmer prostrating himself before a white English customs officer, begging that he be granted reprieve from his dues. Ajit Singh grabs hold of him, stands him up and lets out the shrill cry with the song of 'Pagri sambhal Jatta', whereupon he is promptly seized by security officers and whisked away into custody. This is why Manoj Kumar's 1965 film *Shaheed* is the definitive film on Bhagat Singh. It narrowly escaped not being made because two films already existed and it had no heroine in it. Yet, it stands today as 'one of the most revered films on patriotism' and launched Manoj Kumar's career, making him 'India's de facto patriotic hero' and paving the way for other films such as *Upkar*, *Purab Aur Paschim* and *Kranti* on Indian patriotism. Although directed by S. Ram Sharma and produced by Kewal Kashyap, 'Manoj Kumar accepts that he actually directed it'. Such was the impact of the film that 'Shaheed became an official document for Bhagat Singh's proud mother and the Government of India'. In an interview in 2014, Manoj Kumar explained how

> It took four years of research to prepare for the role. I visited newspaper offices and read old books, magazine, papers, anything that I could lay my hands on regarding the freedom fighters. In Madras (now Chennai), I would go to Hindu Library after completing the shooting of my films that were being shot there and read books. I met Bhagat Singh's lawyer one day and many *krantikaris* (i.e. revolutionaries) who imparted a lot of knowledge about the martyr. It was a gainful insight and helped me during the shooting.

Shooting for the film began in 1963, and after it was released in December 1965, Manoj Kumar became the first actor to win the National Award for Best Writing for *Shaheed*. So popular was the film that it went on to secure the National Award for Best Feature Film in Hindi. No less importantly, it